

# USING COLOR

Color choice is largely about personal preferences, but there are some useful theories on how to match and blend colors that will help you to create pleasing combinations. Remember, too, that light and shade

affect colors and that some visually leap forward, stealing the limelight, while others are more recessive. Color can also affect mood and tone, so choose carefully to create the desired atmosphere.

## Combining colors

Before selecting colors for your beds and borders, it is a good idea to familiarize yourself with some of the principles of color theory, which will help you combine them more successfully.

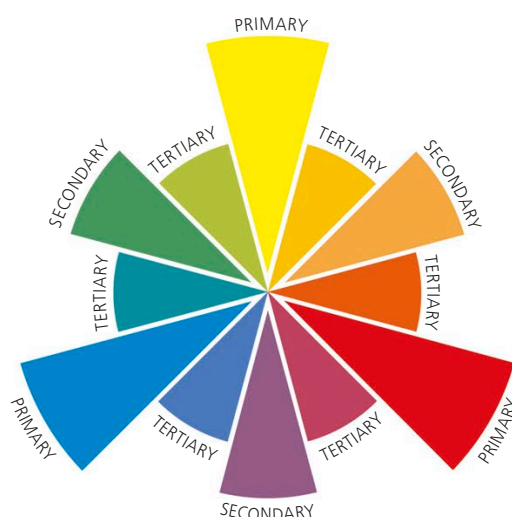
Many designers use the color wheel to make their choices. The wheel is divided into primary, secondary, and tertiary colors. The primary colors are red, blue, and yellow, and when mixed create the secondary colors, green, orange, and purple. In this way, the primaries blue and red produce secondary purple; red and yellow produce secondary orange; and yellow and blue produce secondary green. Tertiary colors are produced by mixing adjacent primary and secondary colors.

The color wheel can help you to create harmonious and contrasting schemes. For example, colors directly opposite one another on the wheel, such as yellow and purple or red and green, are considered to be “complementary.” When placed next to each other, these contrasting colors create a sense of vibrancy and excitement.

Colors that sit next to each other on the wheel are known as “harmonious” or “analogous colors” and create a sense of order. Examples of harmonious colors are blue, purple, and pink, and green, yellow,

and pale orange. Harmonious colors can create different moods, depending on whether you choose hot reds and oranges or cool blues and greens.

Triadic color schemes are created by selecting three colors that are spaced equally apart on the wheel. Green, orange and purple is one example. The contrasting hues can create eye-catching combinations.



**ABOVE The color wheel**

Frequently employed by garden designers, the color wheel is a simple visual device that shows how to combine colors successfully, whether you want a vibrant scheme or a muted, harmonious grouping.



**ABOVE Triadic colors**

Green, orange, and purple are triadic colors. Using them together creates a sense of exuberance, as shown by the fall shades of this group of shrubs.



**ABOVE Harmonious combination**

This border combines adjoining colors: the pale pink *Dictamnus purpureus*, purple-pink *Allium* 'Purple Sensation', and a burgundy-red *Berberis* at the back.



**ABOVE Tints and shades**

This scheme of pale mauve campanulas, darker purple phlox, and deep pink geraniums, uses tints of mauve together with pink to create a balanced scheme.

**LEFT Complementary colors**

Contrasting blue-purple forget-me-nots and bright yellow lily-flowered tulips show how hues on opposite sides of the wheel produce an exciting contrast that draws the eye.

